

— THE FIELD GUIDE

THE 2026 WORLD CUP FORMAT HAS A MATHEMATICAL FLAW.

48 teams. One structural vulnerability.

A 5-part breakdown

SWIPE ►►►

0101 / 05

| THE MATHS.

48 teams. 12 groups of four. Top two advance — plus the 8 best third-place sides. *The margin for error is tiny.*

0202 / 05

| TWO POINTS CAN BE ENOUGH.

Modelling shows a side can reach the Round of 32 on just 2 points. Two draws and a narrow loss. *Survival without a single win.*

0303 / 05

| IT REWARDS THE LOW BLOCK.

Park the bus. Nick one goal. Defend 270 minutes. *Analytically safer than trying to win.*

0404 / 05

FOUR POINTS CAN SEND YOU HOME.

A side can finish on 4 points and still exit on goal difference. *The format punishes mid-tier attackers.*

0505 / 05

| THE ANOMALY, IN A TABLE.

Three sides on 4 points. One elite nation out,
by a single goal. *Architecture over merit.*

— THE TAKEAWAY

ELEVATED, OR **RUINED?**

Save this before kickoff. Does 48 teams elevate the World Cup — or wreck it? Tell us — follow @thearchv_ca.